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AMBASSADOR OF INDIA TO UAE

REFLECTION OF THE TRUST AND CONFIDENCE

While India – UAE relations date back centuries, this decade has witnessed a paradigm shift with the signing of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Agreement in 2017. There has been a re-invigoration of the relations, driven at the highest level through a special personal bond shared by our Prime Minister Sh Narendra Modi and Crown Prince of UAE H.H. Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan. Their vision has been to make the partnership truly comprehensive and deep.

The depth of our friendship and the fortitude and resilience of our nations has enabled India-UAE relationship to evolve and adapt to the challenges of a complex and uncertain world, particularly the Covid 19 pandemic. Our nations have stayed focused on the prosperity and progress of our peoples and the wider world. And it is this resolute focus that fueled our nations to conclude the negotiations of the India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) at an unprecedented pace. It is the fastest free trade agreement to have been negotiated between any two countries, and took a mere 88 days, a reflection of the trust and confidence our nations place in each other.

India – UAE CEPA holds tremendous significance. It is a comprehensive economic pact between the 6th largest economy in the world and the 2nd largest economy in Middle-East. It is the first bilateral trade agreement that the UAE has signed with any country and our first trade pact in a decade. This reflects the value this relationship holds for both our countries. A natural progression for our nations after the signing of the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Agreement in 2017, CEPA provides impetus to a strong and growing relationship, placing it on a fast-paced trajectory. Along with the announcement of CEPA on 18th Feb, our leaders also shared a Joint Vision Statement of our partnership making it future-ready, with a special focus on co-operation in newer and emerging areas such as sustainability, climate action, innovation, digitalization, startups, food and energy security, health, FinTech and skilling.

Historically our economic relations have been centered more around trade in goods, but have witnessed a marked increase in bilateral investments in recent years making the UAE the largest Gulf investor into India. CEPA opens doors to countless opportunities for both trade and investment. While we expect the trade between our nations to reach USD 100 billion in the next five years, I believe the scope is much greater. The agreement is futuristic, comprehensive, and ambitious with a holistic coverage of a wide range of sectors and commitments including over hundred sub-sectors in services, IPR, government procurement, digital trade, telecom. It even looks at the regulatory aspects like rules of origin, dispute settlement, customs procedures, and others in greater depth.

CEPA will usher in a new epoch for India-UAE partnership and contribute to a sustained global recovery, at a tough – but potentially transformative – time. The mutual desire and an unwavering commitment to deliver far-reaching benefits for the peoples of both countries was the driving force behind the negotiations. Today, CEPA stands signed, sealed, and delivered. The stage is set for a new era of prosperity between UAE and India. This agreement is, simply put, a paradigm shift.